PLSC 197 / SODA 110N: Social Data, Technology, and Artificial Intelligence

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Bender et al. (2021): "Stochastic Parrots"

"...we take a step back and ask: How big is too big? What are the possible risks associated with this technology and what paths are available for mitigating those risks?"



Sam Leach, "A Stochastic Parrot in Landscape." Oil on board (2024). https://www.instagram.com/p/C88THDChgVh/

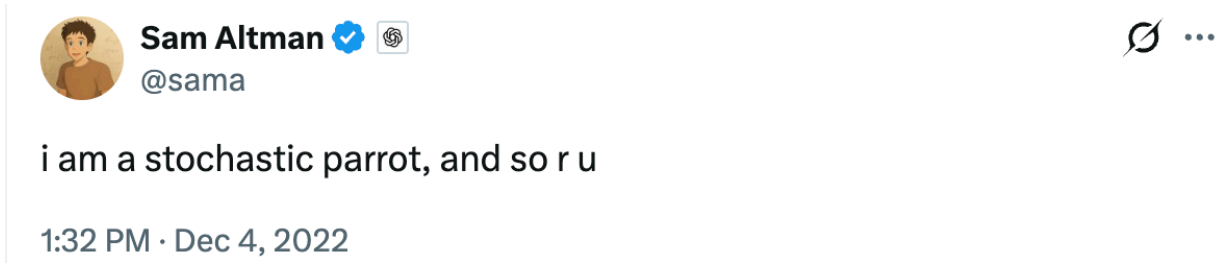
"Stochastic Parrots": Costs

Costs include:

- Environmental and Financial
- Problems with Training Data
- The "Stochastic Parrot" Problem
- Harms From Deployment

Paths forward...

Stochastic Parrot Sequels



Follow-ups:

- Goldberg, Yoav. 2021. "A Criticism of Stochastic Parrots." *Github*, January 23, 2021. https://gist.github.com/yoavg/9fc9be2f98b47c189a513573d902fb27.
- Gerteis, Christopher. 2025. "The Persistence of 'Stochastic Parrots': LLMs and the False Promise of Universality." *Past Meets Pixel @ Substack*, May 17, 2025. https://pastmeetspixel.substack.com/p/the-persistence-of-stochastic-parrots.
- Riley, Benjamin. 2026. "In Defense of Stochastic Parrots." *Cognitive Resonance*, February 16, 2026. https://buildcognitiveresonance.substack.com/p/in-defense-of-stochastic-parrots.
- Mitchell, Margaret. 2026. "No, 'AI' is not a Stochastic Parrot." *Medium*, March 5, 2026. https://medium.com/@margarmitchell/no-ai-is-not-a-stochastic-parrot-a99e57766bed.

Exercise: The Prediction Game